

O2 Xphone II



O2's Xphone II runs on Microsoft's Windows Mobile 2003 unlike others which run the Symbian OS, and this second iteration has been tweaked more than just a bit!

With executive styling, this candy bar style phone sure looks polished. Clever use of black and grey gives it a pleasant aesthetic appeal. The solid construction and feel that O2 products are known for is evident.

The front fascia is occupied by the large 2.2-inch TFT display. The screen, though, is no match for Samsung's or Nokia's high-end phones. This 65K colour screen is capable of displaying 176 x 220 pixels, which is sufficient.

The stub-like joystick is slick and complements the rest of the keys. However, we did find the soft menu buttons too small. The stepped key pad—though cramped—does not hamper operation.

On the back panel is the small VGA-class camera, which seems a little lost in the race, when competitors have megapixel offerings and the

quality of photos is reasonably good.

Powering the Xphone II is Texas Instrument's OMAP 200 MHz processor that makes Windows zoom on this device. The phone comes with 32 MB ROM and 64 MB Flash memory. To further boost memory capability, a mini-SD slot is provided—not hot swappable, though. Despite such speedy hardware the phone does take nearly a minute to boot up.

On the software front, Windows Mobile 2003 for smart phones is rich with applications. The best part of having Windows is the ease of synchronisation with desktop applications such as Outlook.

SMS, MMS and e-mail, along with Internet Explorer keeps you connected. Messaging is a bit tardy and should have been just a click away, instead of three.

For short range communication Bluetooth and Infrared is available along with a USB sync port. The three-day battery life is reasonably good considering the big screen.

Priced around Rs 16,500, the O2 Xphone II is the phone for professionals—if they can break away from Nokia and Sony Ericsson (SE), that is!

Samsung SGH-E730

Mastering the art of designing great clamshell phones, and taking another step forward is the SGH-E730 cell phone.

Measuring 87 x 44 x 23 and weighing just 88 gm, the E730 sets new benchmark for compactness in the clamshell design—it's Compact.

Aesthetically, the E730 looks much better than the E700. The new piano-black finish comes straight off its expensive sibling, the SGH-D500. A dark grey variant is also available.

The E730 incorporates an OLED external display. This 65K colour OLED is sharp and can be set to display a good picture or just tell the time with a classy analogue watch.

Just below the small display are three hot keys for the MP3 player and FM radio. While above the screen is the 1.3 MP camera and a tiny flash.

Flip open the phone and a razor sharp 262K colour screen hits you in the eye. Like all Samsung screens, the display on the E730 is vibrant. The silver keypad has decent size buttons and are easy on the fingers. With nice tactile feedback, they are a boon for

SMS junkies. The flap does seem a little fragile, though...

The E730 also has the same camera as the one on the SGH-D500, and borrows both, the good and bad from it. Video recording is ok, but can't replace your handycam!

The SGH-E730 also has a good Media player capable of playing MP3s and AAC files at decent volumes. A FM receiver with 30 station memory is also bundled in the E730 and requires the headset to be connected.

Connectivity options include Bluetooth and USB. Other features include video and voice recording, 64 polyphonic ring tones, SMS, EMS, MMS, e-mail, and Java 2.0.

The SGH-E730 has a memory capacity of 96 MB, shared dynamically between applications and again, memory expansion is not possible.

Priced at Rs 17,000 the SGH-E730 from Samsung is quite a device if you are looking for a smart, flip-open, compact and feature-rich cell phone. We think it would grace a Lady's hand much better...

